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Bit more than Bitcoin

Undoubtedly, Bitcoin, allegedly invented by Satoshi Nakamoto in 2008, is one of the best-known names in distributed ledger and blockchain technologies, but it is not the only one. Of late, there has been a lot of interest in this space, and many alternatives have come up. Here is a quick look at some of the contenders:

Ethereum. Ethereum is a decentralised platform that runs smart contracts. These are apps that run on a custom-built blockchain, with a platform-specific cryptographic token called Ether. The blockchain can move value as well as represent ownership of property. According to the company, "This enables

developers to create markets, store registries of debts or promises, move funds in accordance with instructions given long in the past (like a will or a futures contract) and many other things that have not been invented yet, all without a middle man or counter-party risk."

Online reviews show that Ethereum transactions are confirmed in seconds compared to minutes for Bitcoin.

Another key difference is that Ethereum uses ethash, while Bitcoin uses secure hash algorithm SHA-256.

The two platforms also differ in purpose. While Bitcoin was intended to be an alternative to regular money, Ethereum is meant as a platform that facilitates peer-to-peer contracts and applications via its own currency vehicle. The focus of Ethereum is not to replace regular money but to facilitate and monetise

the working of Ethereum to enable developers to build and run distributed applications.

Ripple. Ripple aims to be a global settlement network to facilitate instant, certain, low-cost international payments. According to the company, Ripple's distributed network allows foreign exchange to be externally sourced from a competitive foreign exchange marketplace or an internal foreign exchange trading desk via Ripple's FX Market Making Solution.

The backbone of Ripple's network is Ripple Consensus Ledger (RCL), a secure distributed ledger that uses the consensus process to settle transactions. Like other blockchain technologies, it does not require a middleman, and is very secure. The RCL holds the order book with bid/ask offers from payment initiators and market makers. Its path-finding algorithm enables it

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